

▼ COLOR CODE

The bands of color on this rock are different types of organism, including yellow lichens at the top, pale barnacles in the middle, and green anemones at the bottom near the low-tide mark.

LIFE ZONES

Many of the organisms on rocky shores live permanently attached to the rocks. Some animals can survive for longer out of the water than others, which allows them to live higher above the low-tide mark, and have this part of the shore to themselves. As a result, many rocky shores have distinct zones of different-colored animals, seaweed, and other organisms living on the rocks.



▲ FEEDING TIME

Submerged by the tide, these goose barnacles open their shell plates and unfurl feathery limbs to collect floating food particles.

HIGH WATER

When the rising tide covers the rocks, the shore is transformed. Seaweed billows up in the water, and the animals hidden in them emerge to feed. Other animals that live attached to the rocks open up to extend tubes and tentacles that gather food from the water swirling around them. Fish move in to seize what food they can before the falling tide leaves the shore once again high and dry.

ROCKY RETREAT

Rocky shores also provide food for mobile animals such as shorebirds and crabs, which come and go as the tide allows. Seals use rocky shores as safe refuges from sharks and other marine hunters, and as places to warm up after hunting in the cold water.



▲ SUNBATHING

On the tropical Galápagos Islands, marine iguanas bask on the warm rocks of the shore alongside red Sally Lightfoot crabs.

